Women & Energy

(Hybrid)

27 October 2026

Co-Located with IEEE ENERGYCON 2026, CNAM, Paris, France

Objective: During the ENERGYCON 2026 in Paris, IEEE France Section WIE organizes a Side Event called "***Women & Energy***", which is composed of two main activities. First, a **round table** focuses on women's agencies, empowerment, and participation in energy systems. The discussion highlights that true empowerment goes beyond access to energy and involves real influence over decisions, resources, and economic benefits. It also examines how persistent stereotypes and cultural norms continue to limit women's participation, particularly in technical and leadership roles. Additionally, the round table questions whether current energy justice frameworks adequately recognize women as active agents rather than passive beneficiaries. By addressing these issues, the session aims to identify strategies to promote gender equality, strengthen women's leadership, and ensure that energy transitions are inclusive, fair, and transformative for all.

The second activity consists of a **Special Session** on "Women & Energy", featuring five presentations of ongoing scientific research focused on gender equality in the energy sector. This session aims to explore how to strengthen women's leadership and to highlight the diverse ways in which women engage in energy transitions—not only as users, but also as leaders, innovators, and decision-makers. It provides a platform for discussing challenges, sharing best practices, and promoting inclusive approaches to energy development.

Session 1 – ROUND TABLE (Hybrid)

13h30-13h45	**Side Event Introduction** *Bernadette BOUCHON-MEUNIER (Chair of IEEE France Section WIE)*
13h45-15h00 ([Hybrid)	Beyond Access: Empowering Women to Lead the Energy Transition *Moderator: Florence SEDES (Chair of IEEE France Section)* • Maria Kottari, School of Transnational Governance of the European University Institute, the Netherlands • Sylvie Perrin, Deputy Director of RTE's R&D, France and Chair of CIGRE France Women In Energy • Antonia Proka, REScoop.eu, European federation of citizen energy cooperatives, Brussels, Belgium • Verena Tandrayen-Ragoobur, Associate Professor, University of Mauritius, Africa • Adriana Aguilera-González, Associate Professor, ESTIA-Institute of Technology, France

Maria KOTTARI is a Policy Advisor at IIED Europe and an EU Climate Pact Ambassador. She holds a PhD in International, European and Regional Studies and is an energy transition and sustainability specialist with extensive experience in European and international energy and climate policy, innovation, and socio-economic transformation. Previously, she worked at the European Commission's Joint Research Centre (JRC) on energy transition and innovation. Her work focuses on just transition, sustainable finance, women's empowerment, and inclusive approaches to climate action.

Sylvie PERRIN is deputy of RTE R&D, before she was director of an R&D Department TenPoS dealing with voltage, protection and stability issues in an evolving system. She is also director of the transformation of stability processes at RTE. Before joining RTE, she worked at EDF Lab R&D and was head deputy of the System and Market operations. She has also been involved as convenor of a working group in international standardizing in organizations such as IEC (International Electrotechnical Commission). She is also the Chair of CIGRE France Women in Energy.

Antonia PROKA is Head of Capacity Building at REScoop.eu, the European Federation of Energy Communities. Her work focuses on energy democracy, social innovation, gender equality, and the role of citizens in creating a just and sustainable energy system. She is a recognized advocate for inclusive energy communities and has contributed extensively to discussions on community energy, diversity, and citizen empowerment in the European energy transition.

Verena TANDRAYEN-RAGOOBUR is Dean of the Faculty of Social Sciences and Humanities and Associate Professor in Economics at the University of Mauritius. Her research examines gender, energy poverty, vulnerability, and sustainable development, with a particular focus on Africa and Small Island Developing States. She has experience leading international projects on women's empowerment, climate change, and socio-economic resilience.

Adriana AGUILERA GONZALEZ is Associate Professor at ESTIA, Fr. and Head of the Doctoral Unit at ESTIA Research Lab. Her work focuses on renewable energy integration, including modeling, control, optimization, and fault diagnosis of energy systems to support a reliable, resilient, and sustainable energy transition. She is IEEE Senior Member, and she also serves as Secretary of IEEE France Section and IEEE Women in Engineering (WIE) France.

Session 2 – Special Session on "Women & Energy" **(f2f)**
Moderator: Prof. Ehsan Jamshidpour

15h30-15h45 (f2f)	***"Friction in the Transition: Power, Participation and Women in Energy Systems"***, Alison Halford (Assistant Professor at Coventry University, UK)
15h45 – 15h50	Q&A (5 min)
15h50-16h05 (f2f)	***"Women in Engineering: Powering the Future of Sustainable Energy"***, Ehsan Jamshidpour (Professor, Université de Lorraine)
16h05 – 16h10	Q&A (5 min)
16h10-16h25 (f2f)	***"Reliable Power Electronics for Energy Harvesting: High-Gain DC–DC Converters and Fault-Tolerant Control Strategies",*** Niloufar Dizangian (PhD Student, Université de Lorraine)
16h25 – 16h30	Q&A (5 min)
16h30 – 16h45	***"Designing Energy Communities Under Uncertainty: A Simulation and Decision-Support Tool",*** Fatima Zohra Benali (Post-doc, I2M, Université de Bordeaux)
16h45 – 16h50	Q&A (5 min)
16h50 – 17h00	**Closing discussion**

Alison HALFORD is an Assistant Professor at Coventry University, working at the intersection of energy systems, AI, and social justice. Her research focuses on how emerging technologies can be designed and deployed to maximize benefits for underserved communities, particularly in the Global South. She has led and contributed to a range of international projects on inclusive energy transitions, including work on solar e cooking and humanitarian energy systems in sub-Saharan Africa. She is also involved in British Council funded work on women in STEM, supporting leadership development and inclusion in research and education. Her approach combines technical innovation with participatory and co-creation methods, ensuring solutions are grounded in real world contexts. Alison also works on ethics, equity, and data practices in AI enabled systems, with a particular focus on gender and power in technology and energy transitions.

Ehsan JAMSHIDPOUR is a Professor of Electrical Engineering at the University of Lorraine and a member of the GREEN laboratory. He received his M.S. from Sharif University of Technology (2001) and his Ph.D. from the University of Lorraine (2014). His research interests include electric motor drives, fault detection and fault-tolerant control of power electronic converters, and renewable energy systems. He is an IEEE Senior Member and Associate Editor for *IEEE Transactions on Transportation Electrification* and *Power Electronics and Drives*.

Niloufar DIZANGIAN is a Ph.D. candidate in Electronic Systems at the Université de Lorraine and the Institut Jean Lamour (IJL), CNRS, Nancy, France. She received her B.Sc. and M.Sc. degrees in Electrical Engineering from Shahid Beheshti University, Tehran, Iran, in 2016 and 2019, respectively. Her research focuses on advanced power-electronic interfaces for energy-harvesting applications, particularly non-isolated high-gain single-switch DC–DC converters, modeling and control, fault diagnosis, and fault-tolerant operation. Her work also explores artificial-intelligence-based approaches for fault diagnosis in power electronic converters. She has contributed to journal and international conference publications in power electronics and energy harvesting and currently serves as President of the IEEE Student Branch at Université de Lorraine.

Fatima Zohra BENALI is a postdoctoral researcher at the I2M laboratory (University of Bordeaux), working on the planning and design of energy communities. She earned her PhD at Mines Paris - PSL on optimal control strategies applied to building heating. Her first postdoc focused on the optimal management of electrical installations at the scale of a university campus. She is now working on FLEXICOMMU (PSGAR CERENA programme), a project aiming to develop a simulation and decision-support tool that helps stakeholders plan, design and operate energy communities under uncertainty, integrating energy sharing, as well as control and optimization from the early design stages. She applies Dynamic Adaptive Policy Pathways (DAPP), an adaptive planning method, to an institutional energy community.